



SOUBEL COMMERCIAL GROWTH PLAYBOOK SYSTEM

The First 90 Days

A Commercial Growth & Strategic Accounts Executive Playbook
for Industrial Markets

The SOUBEL Commercial Growth Playbook System

Three companion playbooks. One operating philosophy. The system moves from establishing commercial reality, to proving opportunity, to building the enterprise capable of carrying greater ambition.

PLAYBOOK 01 OF 3

ESTABLISH REALITY

Before I start changing this business, what can I responsibly believe about it?

Operational Trust™ = the evidence, economics, decision logic, execution capability, and learning remain connected as commitment increases.

System shorthand: Ambition creates possibility. Evidence earns commitment. Execution creates proof. Repeatability earns scale.

WHERE THIS PLAYBOOK FITS

1 ESTABLISH REALITY	2 PROVE THE OPPORTUNITY	3 EARN THE RIGHT TO SCALE
The First 90 Days Learn the business, test inherited assumptions, and build a defensible fact base.	From Market Signal to Revenue Convert market evidence into qualified commercial plays and durable revenue.	SOUBEL SCALE™ Govern progressively larger growth commitments and build the enterprise behind the ambition.

The Premise

THE FIRST 90 DAYS ARE NOT A PERFORMANCE OF CERTAINTY.

They are a disciplined reduction of uncertainty. A new leader earns credibility by learning quickly, testing inherited explanations without humiliating the people who built them, and converting evidence into a small number of choices the organization can actually execute.

A new commercial leader inherits targets, accounts, relationships, stories, metrics, strengths, frustrations, political history, and usually a revenue forecast. Some of those explanations will be accurate. Some will be stale. Some will have become organizational folklore. Operational Trust begins by preserving institutional knowledge while separating what is known from what is merely familiar.

The purpose of the first 90 days is therefore not to arrive with the answer. It is to establish a decision-grade view of the business: customer and market reality, account economics, commercial capability, delivery constraints, forecast integrity, and the evidence behind the growth thesis.

The 90-Day Objective

By Day 90, leadership should see a better business, not just a busier leader. The output is an inspectable commercial fact base and a clear bridge to the next 12 to 18 months.

- A credible market and customer view, including where customer value is concentrated and where theoretical whitespace is not yet commercially real.
- A prioritized account and opportunity portfolio with explicit Protect / Reactivate / Pursue / Defer decisions.
- The principal commercial, competitive, and operational constraints affecting growth.
- Qualified commercial traction tied to real customer decisions and buying paths.
- An evidence-backed revenue forecast that distinguishes committed, probable, developmental, and speculative revenue.
- The economics and evidence strength behind the leading growth plays, including pricing and cost-to-serve implications.
- A reporting and evidence architecture map showing authoritative sources, common definitions, manual dependencies, data gaps, and the decisions each critical metric supports.
- Operating dependencies that could prevent growth from becoming repeatable at greater load.
- Explicit stop, defer, and test decisions, not a larger list of activities.
- A 12 to 18 month bridge of tests, owners, resources, metrics, and decision dates.

The Three Movements

DAYS	MOVEMENT	DIAGNOSTIC EMPHASIS	LEADERSHIP QUESTION
1-30	ESTABLISH REALITY	Listen + Measure + early Validate	What business did I actually join, what do we currently believe, and which assumptions deserve testing?
31-60	TEST THE THESIS	Validate + Diagnose + Quantify	Which opportunities and constraints survive contact with customers, evidence, economics, and internal capability?

DAYS	MOVEMENT	DIAGNOSTIC EMPHASIS	LEADERSHIP QUESTION
61-90	MAKE CHOICES	Prioritize + Build	Which validated plays deserve resources, which should wait, and what operating changes are required?

Days 1-30: Establish Reality

1. Frame the mandate before the calendar fills itself

- Clarify the growth expectation, time horizon, economic objective, geography, portfolio, and account scope.
- Ask which assumptions leadership most wants tested, not only which initiatives it wants executed.
- Clarify decision rights for pricing, strategic accounts, resource allocation, channel conflict, major bids, and stop decisions.
- Create a hypothesis and contradiction log. Separate observation, explanation, assumption, and evidence.
- Define the handful of non-negotiables growth cannot trade away: customer trust, safety, quality, margin discipline, or delivery reliability.

2. Build the commercial and economic fact base

In industrial markets, a standard sales hierarchy cannot explain an engineering-led, asset-heavy business. The fact base should connect revenue to customers, offerings, gross margin, installed base, channel structure, capital and maintenance cycles, plant / fabrication / field-service capacity, buying behavior, and execution.

FACT BASE	WHAT TO EXAMINE	WHY IT MATTERS
Revenue quality	Revenue and gross margin by account, service/solution, geography, route to market, recurring vs. project, concentration, renewals.	Revenue can grow while economics weaken. The mix matters.
Customer value	Current revenue, margin, strategic relevance, behavior, retention, expansion history, service burden, relationship depth.	Not all revenue creates the same economic or strategic value. Compare margin, cost-to-serve, technical resource demand, working capital, growth potential, concentration, strategic relevance, and delivery burden.
Pipeline / forecast	Coverage, aging, stage conversion, slippage, no-decision, next action, expected decision timing, historical forecast accuracy.	The forecast should explain the number, not decorate it.
Pricing / value capture	Price realization, discounting, exceptions, willingness-to-pay evidence, cost-to-serve, bid patterns.	Price is part of the value strategy and profit model.

FACT BASE	WHAT TO EXAMINE	WHY IT MATTERS
Delivery system	Backlog, utilization, lead time, engineering / technical-review load, plant or fabrication capacity, field-service capacity, specialist constraints, supply availability, shutdown windows, implementation quality.	A commercial promise is only credible when the industrial delivery system can carry it without degrading safety, quality, margin, or customer outcome.
Data quality	Missing fields, inconsistent stages, inaccessible margin data, account duplicates, unverified estimates.	A false sense of precision is worse than a visible gap.

3. Test the reporting architecture before trusting the report

A number can be accurate and still be unsafe to manage from if its definition, source, refresh logic, ownership, or limitations are unclear. The first 30 days should test the information system behind the numbers, not only the numbers themselves.

INFORMATION TRUST RULE

A metric earns trust when its definition, source, assumptions, and decision use remain connected.

- Identify the authoritative source for revenue, margin, pipeline, backlog, pricing, inventory, forecast, channel, and delivery measures used in commercial decisions.
- Confirm whether Sales, Finance, Operations, regions, and channel partners use the same definitions for the measures that are being compared or rolled up.
- Document manual adjustments, spreadsheet handoffs, offline calculations, refresh cadence, ownership, and known data-quality limitations.
- Trace several consequential metrics from source system to executive report so leadership can see where interpretation or transformation occurs.
- Separate data that is unavailable from data that is inconsistent, stale, or contradicted by operating reality. Visible limitations are more useful than false precision.

METRIC / DECISION	DEFINITION	AUTHORITATIVE SOURCE	OWNER / REFRESH	LIMITATION / DECISION USE
Revenue / margin				
Pipeline / forecast				
Strategic-account performance				
Channel / distributor performance				
Delivery / capacity				

4. Take the internal story to the market

- Choose customer conversations that can confirm or challenge the dominant internal explanation.
- Review wins, losses, and no-decisions as customer choices rather than sales anecdotes.
- Test whether claimed differentiation changes customer behavior, risk, economics, or decision confidence.

- Identify regulatory, technology, capital and maintenance cycles, shutdown or turnaround windows, competitor moves, and operating shifts that may be changing buying triggers.
- Look for evidence of customer concentration, emerging segments, declining relevance, or new value pools.

5. Map the commercial operating system

SYSTEM	QUESTIONS
Strategic accounts	Who owns the relationship? Where is trust actually earned? Which business units and decisions are penetrated? What delivery evidence supports expansion?
New logos	How are targets chosen? What buying trigger creates urgency? What proof is required before a customer will switch or act?
Channels / partners	Which partners create access, demand, technical capability, or economic value? Where are ownership and conflict rules unclear?
Sales operations	Do CRM stages correspond to customer evidence? Is forecast logic consistent? Are territories and coverage aligned to opportunity?
Technical / delivery	Where does scarce expertise become the binding constraint? What work consumes capacity without improving win probability?
Leadership	Which decisions depend on one executive, one expert, or one relationship? What must become institutional rather than heroic?

Days 31-60: Test the Thesis

This is where internal explanations collide with customer evidence. The goal is not more activity. The goal is to improve confidence in what deserves commitment.

- Lead with the customer decision, consequence, technical uncertainty, or operating problem rather than the service catalog.
- Map user, technical validator, budget owner, champion, procurement influence, implementation risk, and executive sponsor.
- Qualify against customer consequence, trigger, funding path, right-to-win, access, adoption path, economics, and delivery requirements.
- Segment by problem and economics, not only industry label or account size. Different segments should cause different resource choices.
- Use technical resources only when the commercial question is qualified enough to justify scarce expertise.
- Test price and value together. A technically strong offer that cannot support viable economics is not a durable growth play.
- Reject weak hypotheses. Do not keep an idea alive because a senior person likes it.
- Quantify addressable or recoverable value separately from expected capture. Show assumptions, ranges, and confidence.

Revenue and Forecast Integrity

A FORECAST SHOULD EXPLAIN WHERE THE NUMBER COMES FROM.

A CRM probability percentage is not evidence of customer commitment. Forecast confidence should rise only as observable customer actions, buying milestones, technical qualification, commercial agreement, delivery readiness, and decision timing become visible.

FORECAST CLASS	MINIMUM EVIDENCE	LEADERSHIP USE
Committed	Commercial commitment or contract path is clear; scope, price, timing, delivery and customer approval are materially resolved.	Resource and delivery planning.
Probable	Customer problem, buying path, sponsor, budget/funding logic, technical fit and decision timing are evidenced; material risks are visible.	Operating forecast with explicit risk.
Developmental	Real problem and access exist, but one or more of budget, decision path, proof, price, timing or right-to-win remain unproven.	Pipeline development, not forecast padding.
Speculative	Primarily internal enthusiasm, theoretical whitespace, early signal, or unverified customer interest.	Learning queue only.

Different revenue motions should also be forecast differently. Existing-account expansion, new-logo pursuits, distributor or channel revenue, recurring revenue, long-cycle engineered projects, service work, and one-time transactions have different conversion behavior, timing, evidence requirements, cash profiles, and operating dependencies.

Days 61-90: Make Choices

- Rank the few opportunities that deserve resources by value, evidence confidence, right-to-win, buying path, delivery readiness, time to value, and interdependency.
- Advance qualified opportunities with clear owners, customer next actions, decision paths, value hypotheses, proof requirements, and commercial thresholds.
- Stop or defer pursuits that fail the evidence test. Protect the organization from carrying weak opportunities simply to preserve pipeline volume.
- Turn early traction into reusable account, market, and channel plays only where the customer/problem/capability logic is genuinely comparable.
- Create forecast visibility from evidence, not optimism.
- Establish a minimum governance cadence for opportunity evidence, forecast, pricing, delivery readiness, capacity, and learning.
- Define the 90 to 180 day tests that will reduce the most consequential uncertainty.

Scale Readiness Preview

The First 90 Days should not attempt to solve enterprise scale. It should expose the questions SOUBEL SCALE will need. Before a growth thesis is allowed to become a scale thesis, leadership should know where the current system would strain first.

DIMENSION	DAY-90 QUESTION
Customer architecture	How concentrated is revenue? How many viable customers or expansion paths actually exist?
Revenue design	What mix of project, recurring, service, software, channel, acquisition, or adjacency revenue is emerging?
Commercial capacity	What seller, account-leadership, channel, sales-operations, marketing, and technical-sales capacity would greater load require?
Delivery capacity	What specialist, field, implementation, supply, lab, or service constraint breaks first?
Economics and capital	What working capital, margin behavior, cash timing, and investment would growth require before revenue arrives?
People and leadership	Where does the current model depend on heroic effort or a single person?
Operating process / quality	Which handoffs, controls, and routines must become repeatable without degrading customer outcome?
Evidence & information system	Can leadership reproduce the measures behind a decision, trace them to authoritative sources, apply common definitions across functions, and see where manual work or uncertainty still exists?

The Day-90 Executive Readout

A decision document, not a celebration of busyness.

1. What changed in the leader's understanding of the business?
2. Which inherited assumptions were confirmed, challenged, or disconfirmed?
3. Which customers, segments, and accounts create disproportionate economic or strategic value?
4. Which opportunities passed the Opportunity Reality Gate, and what evidence supports them?
5. Where are the largest commercial, competitive, and operational constraints?
6. What is the evidence-backed forecast, and what could still move it?
7. Which critical metrics can leadership trust as defined and traceable, and which require qualification, remediation, or a better source?
8. What should stop receiving time, capital, or technical resources?
9. What operating constraints threaten the growth plan?
10. What 90 to 180 day tests will reduce the most important uncertainty?
11. What leadership decisions and resources are required now?
12. What evidence and metrics will prove the strategy is working or cause it to change?

Workbook: Diagnostic Evidence Pack

Use these tools to preserve the trail between what was heard, what was believed, what was tested, and what leadership decided.

Hypothesis & Contradiction Log

HYPOTHESIS / INHERITED EXPLANATION	EVIDENCE FOR	EVIDENCE AGAINST	WHAT WOULD CHANGE OUR MIND?	OWNER / NEXT TEST

Account Portfolio

ACCOUNT	CURRENT VALUE	RELATIONSHIP / DELIVERY TRUST	REALISTIC WHITESPACE	MOTION	NEXT EVIDENCE

Opportunity Reality Gate

REALITY TEST	QUESTION	STATUS / EVIDENCE	NEXT ACTION
Consequence	What happens if the customer does nothing?		
Trigger	Why now?		
Decision owner	Who must decide and who bears the consequence?		
Funding path	How could this be paid for?		
Right-to-win	Why this organization?		
Delivery path	Can the promise be delivered reliably?		

Metric & Source Register

Metric	Business Definition	Authoritative Source	Owner / Cadence	Decision Supported

90-Day Decision Bridge

Priority	Decision	Next 90-180 Day Test	Owner	Decision Date	Stop / Redesign Trigger

Handoff Across the System

WHAT THIS PLAYBOOK PRODUCES

A credible fact base, account and opportunity priorities, forecast evidence, an information-source map, operating constraints, and a short list of hypotheses worth greater commitment. From Market Signal to Revenue takes those signals deeper. SOUBEL SCALE uses validated plays and enterprise constraints to decide what deserves progressively larger commitment.

Selected Comparative Context

Soubel uses external strategy, growth, marketing, finance, and scaling literature as comparative context rather than as a substitute for its own operating architecture. The sources below informed questions, stress tests, and terminology choices. No external framework is reproduced as the SOUBEL method.

Wharton Executive Education, Scaling Business for Profitable Growth. Cross-functional scale readiness across strategy, finance, marketing, leadership, KPIs, capital, people, processes, and execution. [Source](#)

Wharton Executive Education, Chief Revenue Officer Program. Revenue as a cross-functional system spanning sales, marketing, customer management, pricing, and revenue operations. [Source](#)

Wharton / Peter Fader, Managing the Value of Customer Relationships. Customer heterogeneity, customer value, segmentation, and resource concentration on economically important relationships. [Source](#)

Wharton Executive Education, Pricing Strategies. Pricing as a strategic value-capture and profitability decision rather than an afterthought. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, High-Impact Sales Strategy. Segmentation, value propositions, integrated go-to-market design, channel mix, key accounts, customer engagement, and execution. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, Business Marketing Strategy. B2B segmentation, targeting, positioning, customer value, account-based approaches, customer success, and loyalty. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, B2B Sales Force Strategy & Effectiveness. Sales structure, territory, strategic accounts, sales operations, CRM, analytics, AI, and change roadmaps. [Source](#)

Roger L. Martin, Strategy. Strategy as a set of interrelated choices about aspiration, where to play, how to win, capabilities, and management systems. [Source](#)

Rita McGrath and Ian MacMillan, Discovery-Driven Planning. Planning and control for uncertain new ventures, with learning and assumption testing before irreversible commitment. [Source](#)

Strategyzer, Testing Business Ideas. Explicit hypotheses, experiment design, evidence strength, and learning cycles before scale. [Source](#)

McKinsey & Company, Three Horizons of Growth. Concurrent attention to current performance, emerging growth businesses, and future options. [Source](#)

Dr. Benjamin Hardy and Blake Erickson, The Science of Scaling. Ambition-led scaling, simplification, elimination of what cannot scale, and designing the system from the future state backward. [Source](#)

ABOUT THIS WORK

Developed by Helen M. Dupree for SOUBEL.

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